

Disaster Recovery Tabletop Summary

Ardent ISD | Exercise Date: October 9, 2026

Scenario

A severe overnight storm causes an extended utility failure at the district administration site. The primary server room loses cooling after generator-supported systems remain online longer than expected. Several on-premises services become unavailable, while cloud services remain reachable from locations with internet access.

Exercise Objectives

- Test leadership understanding of system dependencies.
- Clarify decision authority and communications.
- Identify gaps in recovery priorities and alternate work methods.
- Verify that backup and restoration responsibilities are assigned.

Findings

Finding	Risk	Corrective Action	Owner	Due
Cooling dependency was not visible in the recovery matrix	Servers may remain powered while environmental conditions become unsafe	Add facilities/environmental dependencies and shutdown thresholds to continuity documentation	Technology + Facilities	Nov. 15
Alternate communications were not consistently known	Leaders may lose coordination during a local communications outage	Publish executive continuity contact protocol outside normal email	Communications + Cabinet	Nov. 30
Two business owners disagreed on recovery priority	Restoration sequence may be contested during an actual outage	Cabinet to approve critical-system priority matrix annually	Superintendent's Cabinet	Dec. 15
Restore-test evidence was stored in multiple locations	Leadership cannot quickly confirm recovery readiness	Create a central restricted index of latest restore tests	Systems Manager	Nov. 30
Vendor escalation contacts were current for most, not all, critical services	Delay in external support	Add quarterly vendor contact validation to operations checklist	IT Operations	Quarterly

What Worked

- Staff quickly identified which cloud services remained usable.
- Technology and facilities teams coordinated operational thresholds effectively.
- The district's secondary internet path supported core administrative access.
- Participants understood that business continuity decisions extend beyond the technology department.

Leadership Decisions

1. Add environmental systems to the critical dependency map.

2. Approve one districtwide recovery priority matrix with business-owner signoff.
3. Conduct at least one restore-validation review each semester.
4. Maintain a restricted, offline-accessible continuity contact list.
5. Repeat the exercise with a different scenario next year.

Reference Points

- [CoSN IT Management Resources](#) - K-12 technology operations and leadership resources.
- [USAC E-Rate Program](#) - Federal E-Rate program information for schools and libraries.
- [SETDA Infrastructure for the Future](#) - Guidance for future-ready broadband and infrastructure planning.
- [Future Ready Schools Frameworks](#) - Systems-oriented planning connecting infrastructure, learning, leadership, budget, and equity.

Leadership use: This document is designed to support district-level review, discussion, and decision-making. Technical validation, procurement review, legal review, or compliance review should be completed by the appropriate district specialists when applicable.